25 Cost-Effective, Nutrient-Dense Recipes for Pregnancy & Breastfeeding

1. Blueberry Chia Overnight Oats

Servings: 2
Meal: Breakfast
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 5 minutes + refrigeration
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $2.60

Description

This make-ahead breakfast combines oats, chia seeds, milk, and blueberries for an inexpensive meal containing fiber, calcium, healthy fats, and complex carbohydrates.

Ingredients

- 1 cup rolled oats
- 2 cups 2% milk or fortified soy milk
- 2 tablespoons chia seeds
- 1 cup frozen blueberries
- 2 teaspoons honey or maple syrup
- 2 tablespoons chopped walnuts, optional

Directions

1. Combine oats, milk, chia seeds, and honey in a bowl or jar.
2. Stir until the chia seeds are evenly distributed.
3. Cover and refrigerate overnight or for at least 4 hours.
4. Top with blueberries and optional walnuts.
5. Serve chilled or warm briefly in the microwave.

Chef's Tips

- Frozen blueberries reduce cost and food waste.
- Use fortified soy milk and maple syrup for a vegan version.
- Choose certified gluten-free oats when necessary.
- Walnuts are optional if keeping costs low.

Superfood Spotlight

Chia seeds provide fiber and plant-based omega-3 fatty acids.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Calcium
- Plant-based omega-3 fats
- Complex carbohydrates
- Antioxidant-rich fruit

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Calcium helps support maternal bone health and fetal bone and tooth development.
- Fiber supports digestive health, which can be especially helpful during pregnancy.
- Chia provides alpha-linolenic acid, a plant omega-3 fatty acid.
- Milk or fortified soy milk contributes protein and calcium to help meet increased nutrient needs.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

2. Chickpea Quinoa Power Bowl

Servings: 2
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 15 minutes
Total Time: 25 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.40

Description

A filling plant-based bowl combining quinoa, chickpeas, vegetables, and healthy fats.

Ingredients

- 1 cup cooked quinoa
- 1½ cups cooked chickpeas
- 2 cups spinach
- 1 cup chopped tomatoes
- 1 avocado
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Salt and pepper to taste

Directions

1. Cook quinoa according to package directions.
2. Divide spinach between two bowls.
3. Add quinoa, chickpeas, tomatoes, and avocado.
4. Mix lemon juice and olive oil.
5. Drizzle over the bowls and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Rinse canned chickpeas before using.
- Dried chickpeas cooked in bulk can reduce the cost further.
- Brown rice can replace quinoa for a lower-cost option.
- Add calcium-set tofu for extra plant protein.
- Add salmon or tilapia for a pescatarian variation.

Superfood Spotlight

Chickpeas provide plant protein, iron, folate, fiber, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Plant protein
- Folate
- Iron
- Fiber
- Choline
- Healthy fats

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Folate is required for cell division and healthy fetal development.
- Iron requirements increase substantially during pregnancy to support expanded maternal blood volume and fetal needs.
- Beans contribute choline, a nutrient whose requirement also rises during breastfeeding.
- Fiber supports digestive health.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

3. Lemon Garlic Salmon with Sweet Potato & Broccoli

Servings: 2
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 30 minutes
Total Time: 40 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $8.50

Description

A simple sheet-pan pescatarian meal combining salmon with sweet potato and broccoli.

Ingredients

- 12 oz frozen salmon
- 2 cups cubed sweet potato
- 2 cups frozen broccoli
- 2 cloves garlic
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- Juice of 1 lemon
- 1 teaspoon paprika
- Salt and pepper

Directions

1. Preheat the oven to 400°F.
2. Toss sweet potato with half the oil and seasonings.
3. Roast for 15 minutes.
4. Add broccoli to the pan.
5. Season salmon with garlic, lemon, paprika, and remaining oil.
6. Add salmon and bake another 12–15 minutes, until fully cooked.

Chef's Tips

- Frozen salmon and broccoli reduce food waste.
- Choose salmon from FDA lower-mercury choices during pregnancy.
- Substitute tilapia for a cheaper pescatarian version.
- Replace salmon with calcium-set tofu for a vegetarian or vegan option.

Superfood Spotlight

Salmon provides high-quality protein and DHA/EPA omega-3 fatty acids.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- DHA/EPA omega-3 fats
- Vitamin D
- Beta-carotene
- Fiber

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Fish provides DHA and EPA, which support fetal and infant brain development.
- FDA identifies seafood as a source of omega-3 fats, iodine, choline, iron, vitamin D, and protein.
- Sweet potato provides beta-carotene, which the body can convert to vitamin A.
- Vitamin A is important for normal growth and development.

Evidence:

FDA — Advice About Eating Fish During Pregnancy & Breastfeeding:
https://www.fda.gov/food/consumers/advice-about-eating-fish

NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

4. Peanut Butter Chickpea Energy Bites

Servings: 12 bites
Meal: Snack
Prep Time: 15 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 35 minutes including chilling
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $3.20

Ingredients

- 1½ cups cooked chickpeas
- ½ cup creamy peanut butter
- ½ cup rolled oats
- 2 tablespoons chia seeds
- ¼ cup maple syrup or honey
- 1 teaspoon vanilla
- ¼ cup chocolate chips, optional

Directions

1. Drain, rinse, and dry chickpeas.
2. Blend chickpeas until smooth.
3. Add peanut butter, sweetener, and vanilla.
4. Mix in oats and chia.
5. Fold in optional chocolate chips.
6. Roll into 12 balls.
7. Refrigerate for at least 20 minutes.

Chef's Tips

- Dried chickpeas cooked in bulk can lower the price.
- Use maple syrup for a vegan version.
- Use certified gluten-free oats when required.
- Omit chocolate chips for the lowest-cost option.

Superfood Spotlight

Chickpeas and chia provide plant protein, fiber, folate, iron, and healthy fats.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Fiber
- Iron
- Folate
- Healthy fats

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Chickpeas provide folate and iron, two nutrients with important roles during pregnancy.
- Beans contribute choline, whose needs increase during breastfeeding.
- Fiber supports digestive health.
- The combination of carbohydrates, protein, and fats makes these a convenient snack between meals.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

5. Peanut Butter Banana Chia Oatmeal Bowl

Servings: 1
Meal: Breakfast
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: 5 minutes
Total Time: 10 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $1.05

Ingredients

- 1 cup rolled oats
- 1 cup 2% milk or fortified soy milk
- 1 banana
- 1 tablespoon peanut butter
- 1 tablespoon chia seeds

- ½ teaspoon cinnamon

Directions

1. Heat milk in a saucepan.
2. Add oats and cook until creamy.
3. Stir in chia seeds.
4. Fold in half the banana.
5. Top with remaining banana and peanut butter.
6. Sprinkle with cinnamon.

Chef's Tips

- Use fortified soy milk for a vegan version.
- Freeze overripe bananas instead of discarding them.
- Certified gluten-free oats can be used if needed.

Superfood Spotlight

Chia seeds provide fiber and plant omega-3 fats.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Calcium
- Protein
- Healthy fats
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Milk or fortified soy milk contributes calcium, an important nutrient for maternal and fetal bone health.
- Protein requirements increase during pregnancy.
- Fiber helps support digestive health.
- Chia contributes plant-based omega-3 fats.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

6. One-Pot Lentil Tomato & Spinach Stew

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 30 minutes
Total Time: 40 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.00

Ingredients

- 1 cup dried lentils
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- 2 cups frozen mixed vegetables
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- 1 medium onion
- 4 cups low-sodium vegetable broth
- 1 teaspoon garlic powder
- ½ teaspoon black pepper
- Salt to taste

Directions

1. Sauté onion until softened.
2. Add lentils, tomatoes, vegetables, broth, and seasonings.
3. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer for about 25 minutes.
5. Add spinach during the final 5 minutes.
6. Season and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Lentils do not need soaking and cook quickly.
- Frozen spinach and vegetables save preparation time.
- Add tofu for extra plant protein.
- Add cooked lower-mercury fish for a pescatarian version.

Superfood Spotlight

Lentils provide inexpensive protein, folate, iron, fiber, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Iron
- Folate
- Plant protein
- Fiber
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Folate supports cell division and fetal development.
- Iron requirements increase during pregnancy.
- CDC lists lentils among foods that provide choline, whose requirement increases while breastfeeding.
- Fiber can help support regular digestion.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

7. Pantry Black Bean & Rice Power Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $3.40

Ingredients

- 2 cups cooked rice
- 1½ cups black beans
- 1 cup frozen corn
- ½ cup salsa
- 1 avocado, optional
- 1 tablespoon chia seeds, optional

Directions

1. Cook or reheat rice.
2. Warm beans and corn.
3. Divide rice between bowls.
4. Top with beans, corn, and salsa.
5. Add optional avocado and chia.

Chef's Tips

- Canned beans are convenient; rinse before using.
- Batch-cooked dried beans can be less expensive.
- Avocado is optional when prices are high.
- Add tofu or fish for additional protein.

Superfood Spotlight

Black beans provide protein, fiber, iron, folate, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Fiber
- Iron
- Folate
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Iron and folate are important pregnancy nutrients.
- Beans are a source of choline, which is particularly important during lactation.
- Rice provides an inexpensive energy source.
- Fiber supports digestive health.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

8. Greek Yogurt Berry Chia Parfait

Servings: 1
Meal: Breakfast or Snack
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 5 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $1.65

Ingredients

- 1 cup plain pasteurized Greek yogurt
- ½ cup frozen berries, thawed
- ¼ cup granola
- 1 tablespoon chia seeds
- 1 teaspoon honey

Directions

1. Add half the yogurt to a bowl.
2. Add berries.
3. Sprinkle with granola and chia.
4. Repeat the layers.
5. Drizzle with honey.

Chef's Tips

- Frozen berries are inexpensive and last longer.
- Use fortified soy yogurt for a dairy-free or vegan version.
- Choose certified gluten-free granola if required.
- Plain oats can replace granola for an even cheaper version.

Superfood Spotlight

Greek yogurt provides protein and calcium, while chia provides fiber and plant omega-3 fats.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Calcium
- Fiber

- Healthy fats

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Calcium supports strong bones and teeth and is important during pregnancy.
- Dairy products can contribute iodine, another pregnancy and lactation nutrient.
- Protein supports increased nutritional needs.
- Chia adds fiber and plant-based omega-3 fats.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Iodine & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/iodine.html

9. Caribbean Jerk Tofu, Black Bean & Sweet Potato Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $5.80

Ingredients

- 2 cups cubed calcium-set firm tofu
- 2 cups cubed sweet potato
- 1½ cups black beans
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- 2 cups cooked rice
- 1 tablespoon jerk seasoning
- 1 tablespoon oil
- Juice of 1 lime

Directions

1. Toss tofu and sweet potato with oil and jerk seasoning.
2. Roast at 400°F for about 20 minutes.

3. Warm beans and spinach.
4. Divide rice among bowls.
5. Add tofu, sweet potato, beans, and spinach.
6. Finish with lime juice.

Chef's Tips

- Frozen spinach reduces chopping and waste.
- Use canned beans for speed or dried beans for lower cost.
- Choose calcium-set tofu to increase calcium.
- Tilapia can replace tofu for a pescatarian variation.

Superfood Spotlight

Tofu and black beans provide plant protein, iron, folate, calcium, and other nutrients.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Iron
- Folate
- Calcium
- Fiber
- Beta-carotene

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Calcium is important for maternal and fetal skeletal health.
- Iron and folate contribute to increased pregnancy needs.
- Beans contribute choline for pregnancy and breastfeeding.
- Sweet potatoes provide beta-carotene, a precursor of vitamin A.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

10. Coconut Chickpea & Spinach Curry

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.85

Ingredients

- 3 cups cooked chickpeas
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- 1 cup light coconut milk
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- 1 small onion
- 1 tablespoon curry powder
- 1 teaspoon minced garlic
- 2 cups cooked rice

Directions

1. Sauté onion and garlic.
2. Add curry powder and cook for 30 seconds.
3. Add tomatoes, chickpeas, and coconut milk.
4. Simmer for 15 minutes.
5. Stir in spinach.
6. Serve over rice.

Chef's Tips

- Canned chickpeas and tomatoes make this very fast.
- Dried chickpeas are economical for batch cooking.
- Add tofu for more plant protein.
- Add cooked shrimp or tilapia for a pescatarian option.

Superfood Spotlight

Chickpeas provide folate, iron, plant protein, fiber, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Folate
- Iron
- Fiber
- Plant protein
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Folate is especially important before and during pregnancy.
- Iron helps meet increased maternal requirements.
- Chickpeas contribute choline, whose needs rise during lactation.
- Fiber supports digestion.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

11. Mediterranean Lentil & Rice Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.20

Ingredients

- 2 cups cooked lentils
- 2 cups cooked brown rice
- 1 cup chopped tomatoes
- 2 cups spinach
- ½ cup hummus
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- Juice of 1 lemon

Directions

1. Divide rice and lentils among bowls.
2. Add tomatoes and spinach.
3. Top with hummus.
4. Drizzle with olive oil and lemon.
5. Serve.

Chef's Tips

- Cook lentils and rice in batches.
- Frozen spinach can replace fresh spinach.
- Add tofu for additional plant protein.
- Add cooked fish for a pescatarian version.

Superfood Spotlight

Lentils provide inexpensive iron, folate, fiber, plant protein, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Fiber
- Iron
- Folate
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Lentils provide iron and folate to help meet increased pregnancy requirements.
- CDC identifies lentils as a source of choline, whose requirement increases while breastfeeding.
- Fiber supports digestion.
- Lemon supplies vitamin C, which can help improve absorption of plant-based iron.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

12. Sweet Potato, Black Bean & Avocado Breakfast Bowl

Servings: 2
Meal: Breakfast
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: 10 minutes
Total Time: 15 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $3.10

Ingredients

- 2 cups cooked sweet potato
- 1½ cups black beans
- 1 avocado
- 1 cup spinach
- 2 tablespoons chia seeds
- ½ cup salsa

Directions

1. Cook or reheat sweet potato.
2. Warm black beans.
3. Add spinach and cook just until wilted.
4. Divide between two bowls.
5. Top with avocado, salsa, and chia.

Chef's Tips

- Microwave sweet potatoes for faster preparation.
- Canned beans are easy and shelf-stable.
- Leave out avocado when prices are high.
- Add a fully cooked egg for a vegetarian version.

Superfood Spotlight

Sweet potatoes provide beta-carotene, while black beans provide iron, folate, plant protein, and fiber.

Nutrition Highlights

- Beta-carotene
- Folate
- Iron
- Fiber
- Healthy fats
- Plant protein

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Beta-carotene can be converted by the body into vitamin A, which is important for growth and development.
- Beans contribute iron, folate, and choline.
- Choline requirements increase during breastfeeding.
- Fiber supports digestive health.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

13. Creamy White Bean, Spinach & Tomato Skillet

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: 15 minutes
Total Time: 20 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $3.80

Ingredients

- 3 cups cooked white beans
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- ½ cup pasteurized milk or fortified soy milk
- 1 tablespoon olive oil

- 2 cloves garlic
- 1 teaspoon Italian seasoning

Directions

1. Heat olive oil and garlic.
2. Add beans and tomatoes.
3. Simmer for 5–7 minutes.
4. Add milk and stir.
5. Stir in spinach.
6. Heat thoroughly and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Canned beans and tomatoes make this a fast pantry meal.
- Fortified soy milk provides a dairy-free vegan option.
- Add cooked fish for a pescatarian version.
- Serve with brown rice, potatoes, or whole-grain toast.

Superfood Spotlight

White beans provide fiber, plant protein, iron, folate, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Iron
- Folate
- Fiber
- Choline
- Calcium when prepared with milk or fortified soy milk

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Iron and folate help meet important pregnancy nutrient needs.
- Beans provide choline, which is especially important during lactation.
- Milk or fortified soy milk can contribute calcium.
- Fiber supports healthy digestion.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

14. Caribbean Curry Lentil & Sweet Potato Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 25 minutes
Total Time: 35 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.30

Ingredients

- 1 cup dried lentils
- 2 cups cubed sweet potato
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- 2 cups cooked rice
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- 1 tablespoon curry powder
- ½ teaspoon thyme
- 1 teaspoon garlic

Directions

1. Cook lentils until tender.
2. Cook sweet potato until soft.
3. Add tomatoes, curry powder, thyme, and garlic.
4. Stir in spinach.
5. Serve over cooked rice.

Chef's Tips

- Lentils cook without soaking.
- Frozen spinach saves time.
- Add tofu for more plant protein.

- Add tilapia for a lower-cost pescatarian version.

Superfood Spotlight

Lentils provide iron, folate, fiber, plant protein, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Iron
- Folate
- Fiber
- Protein
- Beta-carotene
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Folate and iron are key nutrients during pregnancy.
- Sweet potatoes provide beta-carotene, which contributes to vitamin A intake.
- Lentils contribute choline for pregnancy and lactation.
- Complex carbohydrates provide energy.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

15. Jerk Black Bean & Pineapple Rice Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 15 minutes
Total Time: 25 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.40

Ingredients

- 3 cups cooked rice

- 3 cups black beans
- 1½ cups pineapple
- 1 cup frozen corn
- 2 cups spinach
- 1 tablespoon jerk seasoning
- Juice of 1 lime

Directions

1. Warm beans and corn.
2. Stir in jerk seasoning.
3. Divide rice among bowls.
4. Add beans, spinach, corn, and pineapple.
5. Finish with lime juice.

Chef's Tips

- Canned pineapple packed in juice is convenient.
- Use whichever is cheaper between fresh and canned pineapple.
- Add tofu for additional plant protein.
- Add cooked tilapia or shrimp for a pescatarian version.

Superfood Spotlight

Black beans provide protein, fiber, iron, folate, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Protein
- Iron
- Folate
- Vitamin C
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Iron and folate support increased maternal nutrient needs.
- Vitamin C from pineapple and lime helps improve absorption of plant-based iron.
- Black beans provide choline, whose needs rise during breastfeeding.
- Rice supplies affordable carbohydrates for energy.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

16. Tofu Vegetable Fried Rice

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 15 minutes
Total Time: 25 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.60

Ingredients

- 3 cups cooked rice
- 2 cups cubed calcium-set firm tofu
- 2 cups frozen mixed vegetables
- 2 tablespoons low-sodium tamari
- 1 tablespoon oil
- 1 teaspoon garlic
- ½ teaspoon ginger

Directions

1. Heat oil in a skillet.
2. Brown tofu.
3. Add frozen vegetables.
4. Add cooked rice.
5. Stir in tamari, garlic, and ginger.
6. Cook until thoroughly heated.

Chef's Tips

- Leftover rice makes this especially quick.
- Frozen mixed vegetables are inexpensive and require no chopping.
- Calcium-set tofu can increase calcium content.

- Use certified gluten-free tamari for a gluten-free version.
- Add shrimp for a pescatarian variation.

Superfood Spotlight

Tofu provides concentrated plant protein and can provide significant calcium when calcium-set.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Calcium
- Iron
- Complex carbohydrates
- Vegetables

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Calcium supports bones and teeth and is an important pregnancy nutrient.
- Protein helps meet increased maternal needs.
- Tofu contributes iron.
- Vegetables add a variety of vitamins and minerals.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

17. Red Lentil Tomato Curry with Spinach

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: 25 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $3.70

Ingredients

- 1½ cups dried red lentils
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- 2 cups frozen spinach

- 1 small onion
- 1 tablespoon curry powder
- 1 teaspoon garlic
- 4 cups water or low-sodium broth

Directions

1. Sauté onion and garlic.
2. Add curry powder.
3. Add lentils, tomatoes, and water.
4. Simmer for about 20 minutes.
5. Stir in spinach.
6. Continue cooking until lentils are tender.

Chef's Tips

- Red lentils cook quickly and do not require soaking.
- Frozen spinach keeps preparation minimal.
- Add tofu for additional protein.
- Serve with rice or potatoes for a more substantial meal.

Superfood Spotlight

Red lentils provide iron, folate, protein, fiber, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Iron
- Folate
- Plant protein
- Fiber
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Iron supports increased blood production during pregnancy.
- Folate supports healthy fetal development.
- Lentils provide choline, whose needs rise while breastfeeding.
- Fiber supports digestion.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

18. Black Bean & Sweet Potato Tacos

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $4.25

Ingredients

- 2 cups black beans
- 2 cups cubed sweet potato
- 8 corn tortillas
- 1 cup shredded cabbage
- ½ cup salsa
- Juice of 1 lime
- 1 teaspoon cumin

Directions

1. Cook sweet potato until tender.
2. Warm beans with cumin.
3. Warm tortillas.
4. Fill with beans and sweet potato.
5. Add cabbage and salsa.
6. Finish with lime.

Chef's Tips

- Corn tortillas can make the recipe naturally gluten-free when certified GF if needed.
- Canned beans make preparation faster.

- Add avocado when affordable.
- Add tofu or tilapia for extra protein.

Superfood Spotlight

Black beans provide plant protein, fiber, iron, folate, and choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Iron
- Folate
- Protein
- Beta-carotene
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Iron and folate help meet increased pregnancy nutrient requirements.
- Beans contribute choline, which is especially important during breastfeeding.
- Sweet potato contributes beta-carotene for vitamin A.
- Lime provides vitamin C to support absorption of non-heme iron.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

19. Tilapia, Brown Rice & Broccoli Bowl

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 20 minutes
Total Time: 30 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $6.70

Ingredients

- 1 lb frozen tilapia
- 3 cups cooked brown rice
- 2 cups frozen broccoli
- 1 lemon
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 teaspoon garlic powder
- 1 teaspoon paprika

Directions

1. Season tilapia with garlic, paprika, lemon, and olive oil.
2. Bake at 400°F until fully cooked and opaque.
3. Prepare or reheat rice.
4. Steam broccoli.
5. Divide rice and broccoli among bowls.
6. Top with tilapia.

Chef's Tips

- Frozen tilapia and broccoli reduce food waste.
- Tilapia appears on FDA's lower-mercury “Best Choices” list.
- Substitute calcium-set tofu for a vegan version.
- Use leftover brown rice to reduce preparation time.

Superfood Spotlight

Tilapia provides lean, high-quality protein and several nutrients found in fish.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- Vitamin B12
- Selenium
- Complex carbohydrates
- Fiber
- Vitamin C

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- FDA recommends 2–3 servings per week of lower-mercury fish for people who are pregnant or breastfeeding.
- Fish provides protein and nutrients including omega-3 fats, iodine, choline, iron, vitamin D, and selenium.
- Broccoli adds fiber and vitamin C.

Evidence:
FDA — Advice About Eating Fish:
https://www.fda.gov/food/consumers/advice-about-eating-fish

20. Banana Chia Peanut Butter Smoothie Bowl

Servings: 2
Meal: Breakfast or Snack
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 5 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: $1.70

Ingredients

- 2 bananas
- 1 cup 2% milk or fortified soy milk
- 2 tablespoons peanut butter
- 2 tablespoons chia seeds
- ½ cup rolled oats
- ½ teaspoon cinnamon
- Ice as needed

Directions

1. Add bananas, milk, peanut butter, chia, oats, cinnamon, and ice to a blender.
2. Blend until thick and smooth.
3. Divide between two bowls.
4. Serve immediately.

Chef's Tips

- Freeze overripe bananas rather than discarding them.

- Use fortified soy milk for a vegan version.
- Use certified gluten-free oats when necessary.
- Add extra milk for a drinkable smoothie.

Superfood Spotlight

Chia provides fiber and plant omega-3 fats, while peanut butter contributes protein and unsaturated fats.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Protein
- Healthy fats
- Calcium
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Milk or fortified soy milk contributes calcium.
- Calcium is important for bone and tooth health during pregnancy.
- Protein and energy needs increase during pregnancy and breastfeeding.
- Breastfeeding generally also requires additional calories to support milk production.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

21. Spinach, Egg & Sweet Potato Breakfast Hash

Servings: 2
Meal: Breakfast
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: 12 minutes
Total Time: 17 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: About $2.75

Description

A quick, savory breakfast made with inexpensive eggs, sweet potato, and spinach. It provides protein, choline, folate, iron, and beta-carotene.

Ingredients

- 2 cups diced cooked sweet potato
- 4 large eggs
- 2 cups fresh or frozen spinach
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- ½ teaspoon garlic powder
- ¼ teaspoon paprika
- Salt and black pepper to taste

Directions

1. Heat olive oil in a skillet.
2. Add sweet potato and cook for 3–4 minutes.
3. Add spinach and cook until wilted.
4. Make four spaces in the mixture and crack in the eggs.
5. Cover and cook until egg whites and yolks are fully cooked.
6. Season and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Microwave the sweet potato first to shorten cooking time.
- Frozen spinach works well and is often less expensive.
- Eggs should be cooked thoroughly during pregnancy.
- For a vegan version, replace eggs with crumbled calcium-set tofu.

Superfood Spotlight

Eggs are one of the richest commonly eaten food sources of choline.

Nutrition Highlights

- Choline
- Protein
- Folate
- Iron

- Beta-carotene
- Vitamin A precursors

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Choline is an important pregnancy nutrient involved in fetal growth and central nervous system development.
- Choline needs increase further during breastfeeding.
- CDC specifically lists eggs among foods that provide choline.
- Spinach contributes folate, while sweet potato provides beta-carotene.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

22. Apple Cinnamon Peanut Butter Overnight Oats

Servings: 2
Meal: Breakfast
Prep Time: 5 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 5 minutes + refrigeration
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: About $2.20

Description

A budget-friendly make-ahead breakfast requiring no morning cooking. Oats, milk, peanut butter, chia, and apple provide carbohydrates, protein, fiber, calcium, and healthy fats.

Ingredients

- 1 cup rolled oats
- 1½ cups 2% milk or fortified soy milk
- 1 apple, diced
- 2 tablespoons peanut butter
- 1 tablespoon chia seeds

- ½ teaspoon cinnamon
- 1 teaspoon maple syrup or honey, optional

Directions

1. Combine oats, milk, peanut butter, chia, and cinnamon.
2. Stir thoroughly.
3. Fold in half the apple.
4. Cover and refrigerate overnight or at least 4 hours.
5. Top with remaining apple before serving.

Chef's Tips

- Use whichever inexpensive apple variety is available.
- Use fortified soy milk and maple syrup for a vegan version.
- Certified gluten-free oats can be used when needed.
- Prepare several jars at once for meal prep.

Superfood Spotlight

Fortified milk or soy milk contributes calcium, while chia and peanut butter provide healthy fats.

Nutrition Highlights

- Calcium
- Fiber
- Protein
- Healthy fats
- Complex carbohydrates

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Calcium is important during pregnancy for strong bones and teeth.
- Protein contributes to increased maternal nutritional needs.
- Fiber supports digestion.
- Breastfeeding increases overall energy requirements, making easy nutrient-dense breakfasts useful.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

23. No-Bake Oat, Date & Chia Energy Squares

Servings: 12 squares
Meal: Snack
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: None
Total Time: 30 minutes including chilling
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: About $3.50

Description

These no-bake squares provide an easy grab-and-go snack with oats, peanut butter, chia seeds, and dates.

Ingredients

- 1½ cups rolled oats
- ½ cup peanut butter
- ¾ cup chopped soft dates
- 2 tablespoons chia seeds
- ¼ cup warm water
- ½ teaspoon cinnamon
- ½ teaspoon vanilla extract

Directions

1. Add dates and warm water to a food processor and blend into a paste.
2. Add peanut butter and vanilla and blend again.
3. Stir in oats, chia, and cinnamon.
4. Press the mixture firmly into a parchment-lined container.
5. Refrigerate for at least 20 minutes.
6. Cut into 12 squares.

Chef's Tips

- Use store-brand oats and peanut butter for the lowest price.
- If dates are expensive, replace half with mashed ripe banana.
- Use sunflower seed butter for a peanut-free version.
- Choose certified gluten-free oats if needed.

Superfood Spotlight

Chia seeds provide fiber and plant-based omega-3 fatty acids.

Nutrition Highlights

- Fiber
- Plant omega-3 fats
- Healthy fats
- Complex carbohydrates
- Plant protein

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Omega-3 fatty acids are among the nutrients NIH highlights as important during pregnancy.
- Fiber supports digestive health.
- Peanut butter and oats make these energy-dense enough for a convenient snack.
- Breastfeeding generally increases daily energy needs.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html

24. Quick Sardine, White Bean & Tomato Toast

Servings: 2
Meal: Lunch
Prep Time: 5 minutes

Cook Time: 5 minutes
Total Time: 10 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: About $4.25

Description

A quick pescatarian lunch combining inexpensive canned sardines, white beans, tomatoes, and whole-grain toast.

Ingredients

- 1 can sardines, drained
- 1 cup white beans, drained and rinsed
- 1 cup chopped tomatoes
- 4 slices whole-grain bread
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- Black pepper to taste

Directions

1. Toast the bread.
2. Combine white beans, tomatoes, lemon juice, and olive oil.
3. Lightly mash with a fork.
4. Spoon the mixture over toast.
5. Top with sardines.
6. Add black pepper and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Canned sardines are shelf-stable and often less expensive than fresh fish.
- FDA lists sardines among lower-mercury “Best Choices.”
- Use gluten-free bread when necessary.
- For a vegan version, leave off sardines and increase the beans to 2 cups.

Superfood Spotlight

Sardines provide protein, omega-3 fatty acids, vitamin D, calcium when the edible bones are included, and other seafood nutrients.

Nutrition Highlights

- Protein
- DHA/EPA omega-3 fats
- Calcium
- Vitamin D
- Iron
- Folate
- Choline

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- FDA recommends 8–12 ounces per week of a variety of lower-mercury seafood during pregnancy and breastfeeding.
- Fish provides omega-3 fats, protein, iodine, choline, iron, vitamin D, and other nutrients relevant to pregnancy and lactation.
- White beans add iron, folate, fiber, and choline.
- Sardines with edible bones can also contribute calcium.

Evidence:
FDA — Advice About Eating Fish:
https://www.fda.gov/food/consumers/advice-about-eating-fish

NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

25. One-Pot Peanut Lentil & Sweet Potato Stew

Servings: 4
Meal: Lunch or Dinner
Prep Time: 10 minutes
Cook Time: 25 minutes
Total Time: 35 minutes
Estimated Total Recipe Cost: About $4.75

Description

A filling one-pot plant-based meal using inexpensive lentils, sweet potatoes, peanut butter, tomatoes, and spinach.

Ingredients

- 1 cup dried red lentils
- 2 cups cubed sweet potato
- 1½ cups diced tomatoes
- 2 cups frozen spinach
- ¼ cup natural peanut butter
- 1 small onion, diced
- 1 teaspoon minced garlic
- ½ teaspoon ground ginger
- 1 teaspoon paprika
- 4 cups low-sodium vegetable broth or water
- Salt and black pepper to taste

Directions

1. Add onion, garlic, lentils, sweet potato, tomatoes, ginger, paprika, and broth to a large pot.
2. Bring to a boil.
3. Reduce heat and simmer for about 20 minutes or until the lentils and sweet potato are tender.
4. Stir in peanut butter.
5. Add spinach and cook another 3–5 minutes.
6. Season and serve.

Chef's Tips

- Red lentils cook quickly and require no soaking.
- Frozen spinach keeps this inexpensive and convenient.
- Use sunflower seed butter for a peanut-free version.
- Serve alone or over rice if a higher-energy meal is needed.
- The recipe is naturally vegan and gluten-free when all packaged ingredients are certified as needed.

Superfood Spotlight

Lentils provide folate, iron, plant protein, fiber, and choline, while sweet potatoes provide beta-carotene.

Nutrition Highlights

- Folate
- Iron
- Plant protein
- Choline
- Fiber
- Beta-carotene
- Healthy fats

Pregnancy & Breastfeeding Benefits

- Folate supports healthy fetal development and cell division.
- Iron needs increase substantially during pregnancy.
- Lentils are among the foods CDC identifies as sources of choline, whose needs increase during breastfeeding.
- Sweet potatoes provide beta-carotene, which the body can convert to vitamin A.
- Peanut butter adds energy, plant protein, and unsaturated fats.

Evidence:
NIH — Pregnancy Nutrition:
https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Pregnancy-HealthProfessional/

CDC — Maternal Diet & Breastfeeding:
https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html